HCM Go-Live Readiness Checklist

Companion to the HCM Go-Live Checklist article · karimchaouki.com

How to use this checklist

Go-live is a gate, not a date — and this checklist is the gate. The project manager carries it into the go/no-go meeting and walks all 30 checkpoints, one by one. Every item must be verifiably complete: not “in progress,” not “almost.” For each checkpoint, record the owner and the date it was verified complete. Anything you cannot check gets a disposition on page 4 — complete it before launch, formally accept the risk, or descope it. It is never ignored.

The seven gates

- **1–6** Configuration
- **7–12** Data
- **13–18** Testing
- **19–21** Compliance
- **22–25** Training & Change
- **26–28** Cutover
- **29–30** Hypercare & Support

1–6 Configuration

- [ ] **1.** All in-scope modules configured per signed-off design documents — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **2.** Out-of-scope items explicitly documented (no ambiguity) — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **3.** Security roles configured and tested (managers see only their teams) — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **4.** Approval workflows tested end to end for every process — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **5.** All customizations documented with maintenance notes — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **6.** Configuration workbook complete and handed to support — Owner _____ Date _____

7–12 Data

- [ ] **7.** Final data migration reconciled: headcount by status, entity, pay group — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **8.** Year-to-date earnings, deductions, and taxes reconciled to zero tolerance — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **9.** Accrual balances (vacation, sick, other banks) verified per employee — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **10.** Benefits elections and dependents validated — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **11.** Data freeze enforced and communicated (no legacy edits) — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **12.** Reconciliation reports signed off by business owners — Owner _____ Date _____

13–18 Testing

- [ ] **13.** System testing complete with all critical defects closed — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **14.** Integration testing complete (payroll, benefits, time, bank files) — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **15.** UAT complete with written sign-off from process owners — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **16.** Accepted defects explicitly listed with remediation plans and dates — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **17.** At least one successful parallel payroll run, fully reconciled — Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **18.** Regression testing complete after final configuration changes — Owner _____ Date _____

19–21 Compliance

- [ ] **19.** Tax setup validated for every jurisdiction (federal, state/province, local) Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **20.** Compliance review completed for all legal entities Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **21.** Data privacy requirements verified (retention, access, consent) Owner _____ Date _____

22–25 Training & Change

- [ ] **22.** HR administrators trained and assessed Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **23.** Managers trained on approvals and team workflows (completion >=90%) Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **24.** Employees informed: self-service access, what's changing, where to get help Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **25.** Go-live communications sent per the communication plan Owner _____ Date _____

26–28 Cutover

- [ ] **26.** Cutover runbook finalized: every task, owner, and timing for go-live weekend Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **27.** Rollback/contingency plan documented, understood, and rehearsed Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **28.** Mock go-live (dress rehearsal) completed successfully Owner _____ Date _____

29–30 Hypercare & Support

- [ ] **29.** Hypercare roster published: names, coverage hours, escalation paths, SLAs Owner _____ Date _____
- [ ] **30.** Hypercare exit criteria agreed in writing with the business Owner _____ Date _____

Go/No-Go decision sheet

Record one disposition per gate. The go/no-go meeting walks all 30 checkpoints above, then signs each gate below.

Gate	Pass	Fail	Defer	Owner	Date
Configuration (1–6)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Data (7–12)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Testing (13–18)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Compliance (19–21)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Training & Change (22–25)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Cutover (26–28)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____
Hypercare & Support (29–30)	○ PASS	○ FAIL	○ DEFER	_____	_____

> **The rule:** any **FAIL** blocks go-live unless a **written contingency** is attached to this sheet.

Dispositions for unchecked items

Any unchecked item gets exactly one of three dispositions:

- **Complete it before launch** — the go-live date moves.
- **Formally accept the risk** — the sponsor signs, and a remediation date is set.
- **Descope it** — documented and communicated to the business.

> *“We’ll figure it out after go-live” is not a disposition.*

Hypercare handoff

Complete before the go/no-go meeting — support owns these answers on day one.

Support model — who takes tickets day 1–30

Escalation contacts (name / role / phone)

First-payroll watchlist

Stabilization & exit criteria

Known-issues log

Final sign-off

Role	Printed name	Signature	Date
Project Manager	_____	_____	_____
Executive Sponsor	_____	_____	_____
Client Payroll Lead	_____	_____	_____